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Cult place, high place

4.7 Cult place, high place

References:

Hebrew בָּמָה (bamah) LEV 26:30, NUM 33:52, 1SA 9:12, 1SA 9:13, 1SA 9:14, 1SA 9:19, 1SA 9:25, 1SA 10:5, 1SA 10:13, 1KI 3:2, 1KI 3:3, 1KI 3:4, 1KI 11:7, 1KI 12:31, 1KI 12:32, 1KI 13:2, 1KI 13:32, 1KI 13:33, 1KI 13:33, 1KI 14:23, 1KI 15:14, 1KI 22:44, 1KI 22:44, 2KI 12:4, 2KI 12:4, 2KI 14:4, 2KI 14:4, 2KI 15:4, 2KI 15:4, 2KI 15:35, 2KI 15:35, 2KI 16:4, 2KI 17:9, 2KI 17:11, 2KI 17:29, 2KI 17:32, 2KI 17:32, 2KI 18:4, 2KI 18:22, 2KI 21:3, 2KI 23:5, 2KI 23:8, 2KI 23:8, 2KI 23:9, 2KI 23:13, 2KI 23:15, 2KI 23:15, 2KI 23:15, 2KI 23:19, 2KI 23:20, 1CH 16:39, 1CH 21:29, 2CH 1:3, 2CH 1:13, 2CH 11:15, 2CH 14:2, 2CH 14:4, 2CH 15:17, 2CH 17:6, 2CH 20:33, 2CH 21:11, 2CH 28:4, 2CH 28:25, 2CH 31:1, 2CH 32:12, 2CH 33:3, 2CH 33:17, 2CH 33:19, 2CH 34:3, PSA 78:58, ISA 16:12, ISA 36:7, JER 7:31, JER 19:5, JER 32:35, JER 48:35, EZK 6:3, EZK 6:6, EZK 16:16, EZK 20:29, HOS 10:8, AMO 7:9

Description:

The Hebrew word bamah has been defined as “a raised elevation, platform, or mound often alongside or near a sanctuary and set up primarily for the purpose of sacrifices.” One of the forms that it could have was a round platform varying in height and diameter. Some were provided with steps at the side so that the worshiper or priest could go up onto the platform. Each high place had at least one altar, which was situated either on the platform or beside it. Both the platforms and altars were made of stone.

Translation:

The name “high place” is a somewhat misleading translation of bamah. While the Hebrew word can include the element of elevation, this is not its primary focus. More important is that it was a site where religious rites and sacrifices—primarily pagan—took place. In most passages where this word occurs, it is best to make explicit that these sites were “places of worship” (so GNT) and that they were generally associated with pagan cults. Some translations have rendered bamah as “sanctuary” (SPCL in 1KI 11:7) or “place of sacrifice” (GECL in 1KI 11:7). If the context does not make it clear that the text is speaking of pagan sacrifice, then it will be necessary to expand the translation to clarify this. Thus SPCL usually adds the word “pagan” or even expands to “high places of pagan cultic worship” (1KI 3:2). Something like this is recommended.

If there is a word in the receptor language for a “shrine” or a place where offerings are placed for fetishes, this may be appropriate. Where such a word is lacking, translators can always say “places where various gods are worshiped.”

In a few passages the word bamah indicates an Israelite place of worship. See, for example, 1SA 9:12; 1SA 9:13; 1SA 9:14; 1SA 9:19; 1SA 9:25; 1SA 10:5; 1SA 10:13; 1KI 3:2; 1KI 3:3; 1KI 3:4. It is significant that these examples come before the dedication of the Temple by Solomon. The later writings of the Old Testament condemn not only pagan worship at the “high places,” but also Israelite worship at any place except the Temple at Jerusalem. In these later books, in fact, “high place” seems to indicate any sanctuary not recognized by the official authorities. Because of this tendency, it is not recommended that one standard translation, such as “pagan places of worship,” be adopted except where the context clearly indicates that this is the case. A translation such as “country temple” for an unauthorized worship place should be avoided, lest readers think that there were temples in the rural areas similar to the Temple in Jerusalem. “Country shrine” may be a good neutral expression, but perhaps the best translation, at least in those passages where unauthorized worship is condemned, is “illegitimate places of worship” or “places where people were not supposed to offer sacrifices.” Translators will normally be able to employ the same word or phrase whether the text is speaking of Israelite or pagan worship.